

Stay Safe and Warm Toolkit

Purpose

This toolkit provides messaging, graphics and resources to help your community stay safe in cold temperatures.

By sharing these messages, you can teach community members how to:

- Get updates from local government and first responders.
- Keep themselves and their homes warm during a power outage.
- Be safe warming their homes.
- Recognize the signs of frostbite and hypothermia.
- Seek help or shelter at alternative locations when necessary.

Toolkit Sections

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Ready.gov

[FEMA's #WinterReady page](#) has tips and resources people can use to learn how to protect themselves from common cold-weather risks, including [power outages](#), [home heating fires](#), [working outside](#) and [traveling by car](#) when safe to do so. The page also includes links to CDC resources about how to identify and prevent [frostbite](#) and [hypothermia](#).

Social Media Toolkits

Ready.gov features a social media toolkit in [English](#) and [Spanish](#) with suggested safety messaging and graphics you can share on your social media channels. You can either copy these messages directly or customize them to reach your audience. [Safety graphics](#) are available for sharing.

Note: English is the official language of the United States of America. Translation for the toolkit is provided due to the life saving and life sustaining nature of the information. The original English version of the toolkit serves as the authoritative source for this information.

We also encourage you to share and amplify this state shelter information from FEMA's social media accounts:

- [FEMA State Shelter Information on X](#)
- [FEMA State Shelter Information on Truth Social](#)
- [FEMA State Shelter Information on Facebook](#)

FEMA Blogs

[5 Ways to Safely Weather the Storm](#)

[5 Ways to Help Your Neighbors After the Winter Storm](#)

Sample Text for Social Media, E-mails, Handouts, Articles, Flyers and More

Keeping Your Home Warm

- Severe winter storms can bring extended power outages. Make sure you heat your home safely. Be careful if you use a generator: keep it outdoors and at least 20 feet away from windows, doors and garages.
- Make a plan now for how you will stay warm if you lose power. Look up the location of a nearby warming center and make sure you know how to get there.
- If your power goes out, it is important that you stay safe and warm inside. Close the vents and shut the doors in rooms you're not using.
- If your power goes out, it is important that you stay safe and warm inside. Place a rolled towel at the bottom of all doors to keep drafts out.
- You can help keep your home warm by opening window coverings like blinds or curtains during the day to take advantage of the sun's heat – especially windows that get direct sunlight. Close them at night to keep heat from escaping.
- If you are using a space heater to stay warm, plug it directly into an outlet and make sure its cord isn't damaged or frayed.
- You may want to light a fire in your fireplace to keep warm during winter weather. Make sure the flue is open so that smoke can safely exit the chimney to reduce the risk of carbon monoxide. Remember to never leave an open flame unattended. Keep anything that can burn at least three feet from open flames.
- You can stay warm by dressing in several layers of loose clothing. Layering provides better insulation.
- Snow and freezing rain can bring the risk of power outages. If you lose power during a winter storm, don't use a gas stove or oven to heat your home.

Alerts

- Being able to get alerts and warnings is critical because forecasts can evolve, and a storm's effects may change. Sign up for state and emergency alerts from your local public safety officials. Check the batteries in your radio. This may be your main source for alerts and updates during a power outage.
- Download the [FEMA App](#) to receive real-time weather and emergency alerts for up to five different areas nationwide, send notifications to loved ones, locate emergency shelters in your area, get preparedness tips and more.

Warming Stations

- If you can't keep your house warm, go to a community warming center. Visit your community's emergency management website to learn about warming centers or shelters. You can also call 211 which can help you locate help if you need it.
- Make a plan for your pets: Community warming centers may not allow pets. If possible, call to ask before leaving home with your pets. Your local humane society may have more information or resources.

Road Safety

- **During a winter storm, follow guidance from local officials.** If they ask you to stay off the roads, please do so.
- **Check your local weather and traffic reports before heading out for essential travel and keep supplies in your car.** Tell others your route and anticipated arrival time. Keep an emergency kit in your car including blankets, food and water, first aid and [other items](#) you may need if you get stranded.
- **Slow down.** It takes longer to slow down on slippery roads: If you must drive, increase your following distance to other vehicles to 5-6 seconds and watch for slippery conditions and raised surfaces. Make sure you have your auto insurance provider and a towing company number in a place that's accessible.
- **If trapped in your car during a blizzard or freezing temperatures, remain in your vehicle** unless you can see a building close by where you know you can take shelter. Run the engine and heater for about 10 minutes each hour to keep warm. Make sure the exhaust pipe is clear of snow to prevent carbon monoxide poisoning.

Outside Safety

- **It's best to stay at home** during and immediately after a winter storm, but if you must go out, be [ready for the cold](#).
- **Dress properly.** Dress in layers and cover as much skin as possible. Make sure to protect your ears, face, hands and feet. Boots should be waterproof and insulated. A hat will keep your entire body warmer.
- **Watch for signs of frostbite and hypothermia.** This can include numb, grayish-yellow or waxy skin, shivering, confusion, fumbling hands, slurred speech or drowsiness. Know [how to treat these conditions](#).
- **Watch out for freezing rain.** If you must go outside and it's slippery, wear sturdy shoes with good traction. To help maintain balance, keep your hands out of your pockets, take slow, short, shuffling steps and keep your center of gravity over your feet.
- **Be careful when shoveling snow.** If you're shoveling snow, take breaks and work at a comfortable pace. Overexerting yourself could cause a [heart attack](#).

Radio Scripts

Script for a 30-Second PSA

If your home is freezing, try:

Layering up: wear loose lightweight clothing and bundle up in blankets or coats.

Sealing the heat: close vents and doors in unused rooms. Blocking drafts with towels or rags.

Eating and drinking – to help you stay warm.

If it's safe to travel, call 2-1-1 to find a warming center near you.

Script for a 15-Second PSA

Can't get somewhere warm after a winter storm?

Layer up in warm, loose clothing.

Close vent and doors in unused rooms. Block drafts. Open blinds in the day and close them at night.

If it's safe to travel, call 2-1-1 to find a warming center near you.

Additional Partner Resources

U.S. Fire Administration

FEMA's U.S. Fire Administration has many downloadable, co-brandable graphics and materials on a wide variety of fire safety topics for social media and more.

- Website link: [USFA | Prevent Home Fires](#)
- Flyers: [#WinterReady Safety Flyers and Handouts | Ready.gov](#)

Additional fire preparedness materials can be found on the [U.S. Fire Administration Fire Prevention and Community Risk Reduction page](#). Most graphics and publications can be co-branded with your city emergency management or fire department logo.

The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention

The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention educational materials page provides fact sheets, flyers and pictograms in multiple languages for many common cold-weather hazards, including carbon monoxide poisoning, generator and furnace safety. Additionally, materials on preventing, recognizing and treating hypothermia are available in English and Spanish at the second link below.

- [CDC | Carbon Monoxide Poisoning Basics](#)
- [CDC | Preventing Hypothermia](#)
- [CDC | Preventing Frostbite](#)
- [CDC | Heating Homes Safely](#)